**1. Introduction 2. The Curse of Crypto Castle**

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at https://archiveofourown.org/works/93398606.

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Mature

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Graphic Depictions Of Violence

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F/F, F/M, Gen, M/M, Multi

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She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

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Part 2 of Tales of Terror for Cowering Cadets by Old Mother Weaver

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# 1. Introduction 2. The Curse of Crypto Castle

by Breavedbuckle, Caroelbo, brekoftheHorde, KurakKihomieli, sometipsygnostalgic, TheRisenArsonaut, ThiaKrrigan, ThornChaosPHD, unlimitedtogether, Xnakis (theRosesCrown)

## Notes

See the end of the work for notes

# Chapter 1: Prologue and poem

Chapter Summary

Old Mother Weaver
Youll never believe her
Tales of terror and woe!
Evil princesses
In eviller dresses
Tied off with their blood-red bows!

Poem by Thia Karrigan

Shadow Weaver told many tales to the Cadets of the Etherian Horde.
These are but some of those chilling stories in time for Halloween.




Prologue by Shadow Weaver

Old Mother Weaver was a gentle old soul full of wisdom and loyalty to the good nature of the Horde teachings. She loved children and would often tell them bedtime stories, gathering as many as she could find around her each evening. Especially on dark and stormy nights when the children would be most afraid. Generally these stories took the form of exciting tales of Horde superiority and successful conquering of the planet Etheria but, on occasion, she would lean in and bid the children come closer. On these dark nights she would tell tales of the Evil Princesses whose powers were so

corrupt as to drive each one of them to insanity and macabre deeds of destruction. So captivating were these stories that the Horde cadets would sit in complete silence, their little faces awash with rapt interest as they clutched one another for support. Huddled under blankets they shivered with fear as the stories grew bolder and whenever a scream was uttered Old Mother Weaver would smile to herself at a job well done.  Headless, phantom, vampire or demon, each princess was awarded a tale of her own and Old Mother Weaver was a master of storytelling.

These tales are some of those of which she told. They have been compiled at great length and sacrifice by myself, the lowly Shadow Weaver. Ihave tried to recreate the passion and dexterity of the originals but my storytelling is merely a shadow of the original tales, if Ido say so myself.  Ialways do think a story is best told aloud and not in book format but needs must Isuppose.

To all of you out there who think you can handle the stories told within, be warned! Old Mother Weaver's stories are not for the faint-hearted. For those of you who dare to turn the pages, good luck to you. You will need it.

Poem - Old Mother Weaver

Old Mother Weaver
When she wanted to scare
Would often tell tales
Others never would dare

Of dangerous princesses
Magically powered
And Horde Soldiers
Lured to their deaths and devoured

The tiny tots trembled
Their hearts all aflutter

As they sat there
And listened with barely a mutter

Old Mother Weaver
Her voice cracked and grim
Would regale many tales
Then sit back with a grin

Then in the silence
which oftentimes fell
came the blanket of darkness
and bedtime, as well.

# Chapter 2: The Curse of Crypto Castle

Chapter by Breavedbuckle , sometipsygnostalgic

Chapter Summary

> One dark and stormy night a lonely Horde Cadet, lost in the wilderness, comes across a castle. Looking for shelter, he wanders inside to find things he never dreamed off. But despite the luxurious setting, something is amiss. What secrets are hidden within the fortress walls and why is this Princess the once they were told to never trust no matter what?

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

The young cadet trudged on into the bitter wind's wrath. Rain pummelled his exposed face;blond hair stuck to his forehead. His hood had blown away in a gust so strong it ripped the stitches along the seam in a burst of sudden, agitated delight. His feet sloshed at each step, weighed down by waterlogged boots. He hugged the oilskin cloak tight to his midsection, the chill crawling over his skin to reach his weary bones. It didnt keep the cold and wet away but offered at least a modicum of comfort in this treacherous terrain.

A crash of thunder. A bolt of lightning. A castle upon a mountainous path, calling him. He shivered. He had lost his pack somewhere in the foliage when he had slipped. No supplies, no tent, no way to call for help. He hadnt meant to get lost;to find himself isolated on a stormy night. Welcoming lights drew him onward, keeping him going, but as he drew closer to the stony outer walls, misgivings began to surface. Even though he had never been here before, the grey architecture, geometric shapes and the spire felt strangely familiar. He arrived at an enormous wooden door, pressed a hand to it, and pushed. It swung open on well-oiled hinges and he stepped into an eerily empty courtyard. It was strange, he considered, to find an

isolated fortress so easily accessed. So focussed was his quick pace towards the main entrance, he did not notice the slab move until he tripped over it. He sat up to find green eyes staring at him in disbelief, the small goblin holding the stone high for shelter from the incessant rain.

"Run, you fool! Run and don't look back! Don't you know this is the castle of Princess"…

A rattle of thunder obscured the last words but the terrified cadet had witnessed something far more sinister atop the spire which glowed in the darkness. Someone was using it as a lightning conductor. He jumped to his feet and made a mad scramble inside, slamming the doors in a bid to block out the image now ingrained in his mind. That of a figure, arms reaching for the heavens, legs splayed and head focussed upwards, cackling with delight as tendrils of hair swarmed like snakes or…lightning rods? His eyes opened wide as he realised the hair had been training the energy of the moon goddess herself directly into the spire in a haze of deep purple electrical energy .

He had to leave. Now . This Princess was trouble. Hadn't Shadow Weaver spoken of her ability to move silently like a ghost, perhaps she was a ghost, to steal children and cadets from their beds while they slept, for what evil purposes no one knew. He grabbed the handle of the castle door and turned but, somehow, it had become locked, trapping him. Panic began to swell inside his chest. He remembered the stories. It was said to be a maze, only navigable by the Princess herself. He ran to the window, making a fist to smash it but a sound made him falter. He turned to find a pair of soft lilac eyes staring at him, metallic face blushing. The robot urged him gently to a room where he found soft fabric furnishings all in purple, a thick lilac carpet, beautiful wallpaper with a patterned cog insignia and the largest fireplace he'd ever seen.

Oh how good to feel the warmth upon his skin, his clothes begin to dry. He glanced in embarrassment at the wet trail from the door to the fireplace. His Horde uniform was thin and dried fairly quickly but the cloak was still soaked through, the boots too wet to wear though

he dare not take them off. He shivered despite the warmth. The Technological Princess. She was here. This was her castle and he was an interloper. He knew of the danger but the storm outside had not abated and he could not leave. In the quiet, his eyes strayed around the room. There was a distinct absence of both clocks and mirrors. An odd painting above the fireplace caught his eye. A cat sporting a tiny bow tie and a large head glared down at him in distain. He jumped despite himself then chastised his own foolishness.

"It's just a painting," he said, to no one in particular, but kept his eyes open all the same. The door creaked. He spun around to find two tray-layden figures approaching.

"Welcome to Crypto Castle." He returned Baker's warm smile with a wobbly one of his own as she introduced herself and Soda Pop. They set down trays of several small glasses and tiny treats and stepped back, smiles stuck to their faces as though painted on. He hesitated. Hadn't Shadow Weaver warned every cadet never to eat or drink the food of the Princesses? Didn't they use their magical abilities to enchant that very sustenance of life in order to control, to entrench their vile ideals upon the masses? But the Technological Princess had no magic, or had he misheard? Dammit, he was hungry and could wait no longer. He grabbed for tiny cupcakes, mini sandwiches, petit fizzy drinks. The more he ate the more he wanted. Never had he consumed so much food of such delicate and exquisite texture and taste. The Horde did not offer such rations, never allowed its delegates to indulge so profusely. He was hungry but this was more than simply hunger, it became an urge to satisfy some deep-seated emptiness within. Something he could not identify nor quench. Eventually he was full. He glanced up to find the painted cat staring at him morosely, chiding his foolishness. Hadn't it been looking the other way?

Baker coughed. "The storm is getting worse," she said, "You had better stay the night." A roll of thunder followed her words and a

shiver ran up the cadet's spine. Without quite knowing why, he followed them, deeper into the castle and unknown territory.

"Hey Kyle," unbidden, he imagined Lonnie chastising him, "Dont you know anything? Never follow anyone to a place you dont know. Unless they're Horde, you can't trust 'em. And that's a fact!"

Beyond the door, the main entrance had gone. The high vaulted ceilings, the cloisters, the huge stairwell. In place was now a gallery of artworks; all manner of ancestry and several pets of bygone eras. The grumpy cat glared at him anew as they walked, he was sure he passed it several times over; its eyes, as ever, following his path. He asked where they were going but Baker and Soda Pop did not hear him. A rustling, swishing sound caught his attention. Turning, he found nothing but darkness; the only area lit up was the one he now stood in. A strange pair of bright red orbs hovered at the end of the corridor. The cadet turned again to find Baker and Soda Pop had vanished without trace. Nervous, he resumed his onwards march along the endless corridor. Where was this maze he had been warned of? It was nothing but paintings of dead cats and he jogged to the next portrait. Yet again the black cat glared at him, the tiny bow tie haughtily regarding him as one might look upon a distasteful sour fruit. Why was this cat so prevalent?

"He's cute right?"

The jarring voice so close to his ear made him jump. Heart in his mouth he turned to find a metal face right beside him, the bright red orbs glowing ominously. He screamed and ran down the corridor at breakneck speed. It was her! She had stood right next to him. A Princess! Lonnie and Rogelio would have scolded him for even entering the castle. He wished he were back in the Fright Zone. Past yet another portrait of the arrogant cat, one of the Princess as a child and two robots? Didnt she have parents? Even the cadets had had parents once. He tossed the idea in his mind as he ran, frozen with fear as he was. She was said to be the oldest of all the Princesses and the cadets had often tried to work out her age from the stories told of her.

"She' s well over a thousand years easy," Lonnie had decided, "That' s how she knows all that First Ones crap. I mean duh, she was there right?"

"Three thousand," Rogelio had argued, "She has to be older than Angella. Stands to reason. Otherwise why would everyone call her the oldest Princess?"

He had worked it out mathematically and concluded she must be around thirty or so. Give or take a year or two. After all she was born around the start of the war and everyone knew the date Hordak had arrived on Etheria. It was in the manuals Hordak had written himself. Actually, now he came to think about it, was he the only one who actually read the manuals? He felt a trickle of malcontent niggle at his psyche til he brushed it off.

She was chasing him. He could hear her boots thudding, the cackle of laughter, the smell of oil and sulphur. He felt the floor beneath his feet, solid, the only real thing in this hideous world and then… nothing.

The trapdoor closed above his head as he fell, into the darkness. He landed in a large chamber, stone floor and walls cold and windowless. He listened, urging his breath to slow, his heartrate to lessen. There was a sound of soft tinkering from behind a bank of computer terminals. Standing up, he quietly followed the metallic sounds until he found the source. A figure in purple stood before a workbench in oil-soaked overalls of a deep purple hue. Why was everything purple? Was there no imagination here at all?

Suddenly, he knew where he was, inside her lab, and he stepped back, horrified. He bumped into a line of robots causing them to fall like dominoes. The noise would have woken the First Ones themselves but the engineer didn't even look up from her work. The robots moved, their eyes lit up in garish red hues, narrowed with malicious intent. They surrounded him. He cried out for help, imploring the Princess to stop the onslaught but she vanished from view. Just as he was beginning to tire of fighting off the ceaseless

onslaught, a tendril descended from a rafter wrapping itself around his waist. It hauled him upwards, away from the cantankerous machines and into the vents above. With a sigh of relief, his body shaking, he looked up to thank his rescuer.

"You're welcome!" she waved a hair hand, a wide smile on her pretty, unassuming face. Despite his misgivings he wondered if, maybe, Shadow Weaver's warnings were wrong. After all she'd taken him in, offered him food, rescued him from the robots. Maybe…

"Now, let's do science!" the voice was suddenly cold, deliberate.

The mask slammed down, a sudden, hideous feature devoid of feeling. A flame thrower appeared in a strand of hair, a knife in another. He screamed, turned and scurried along the vent shaft, a deranged cackle mocking him as he scrambled and slid his way forward. A strand wrapped around his ankle. He struggled against its grip;closed his eyes. The metal beneath him gave way and he fell into a corridor where another servant stood, as though awaiting him patiently. Introducing herself as Bowgirl, she ushered him to follow her to a room of such opulence it took his breath away.

"Is this the guest room?" A clap of thunder rolled as he spoke as though mocking the very idea. Bowgirl giggled. A macabre sound.

"Guestroom? Oh no! This is Princess Entrapta's bedroom. She specifically requested you sleep here tonight."

The cadet shivered, his blood running cold, "But?.. Where will she sleep if I'm"…

Bowgirl's eyes narrowed. Thunder and lightning struck again, showing up her face on one side only, the other drenched in shadow. The bedroom seemed cavernous as she pushed him inside.

The former friendliness drained away leaving only a rocky terrain of facts and instructions. "There's a storm outside. This is the only room we have ready. You can leave in the morning."

And then he was alone. Looking around, it was a crowded mess of lace and lavender. Every surface filled with dolls;all identical except in size but all of them miniature variations of the Princess of Dryl herself. He couldnt fathom the reason for their existence. Surely the Princess was too old for dolls. There were no mirrors or clocks, no personal items such as a hairbrush. Evidently, this room was not in use. Where did she sleep? He took his boots off, moving towards a huge bay window overlooking the courtyard, his tired feet grateful for the warmth and softness of the thick carpet. He found his eyes drawn to the spire where it stood silent and dark. He could hardly believe he'd seen that ominous figure standing astride it, alive with colour and energy. The laughter still haunted his memories and he closed the heavy fabric curtains with a shudder.

Turning back to the room he found himself facing the enormous bed. Deep purple bedsheets, embellished with lilac lace, lay flat and heavy across its surface;fluf fy pillows piled high against a padded headboard. There were no dolls there and he was grateful. They felt rather creepy to him with their glassy, staring eyes and rigid limbs. At the edge of the bed he found a small pile of clothing;silk lilac-coloured pyjamas and fluf fy bunny slippers. He screwed up his nose at the very idea, who ever heard of a Horde Officer wearing silk anything let alone bunny slippers. He shivered as his body finally gave way to the cold and shock of the evening. He sighed and considered his options. The room was warm and cozy while the storm outside rattled on. At least he could get a good sleep and leave tomorrow. A large yawn eeked out of his mouth unbidden and his mind was made up. Peeling off his dirty uniform, he tugged on the silk pyjamas, marvelling at their soft sheen and cosy warmth. The bunny slippers fell to the floor as he pulled back the enormous duvet and climbed into the bed, switching off the light as he did so. As he snuggled into the sweet-smelling mattress his felt his mind shifting towards sleep, his eyes shutting out the wind and rain, his ears using the sounds as a lullaby to gently rock him into blissful unconsciousness. He'd never enjoyed such luxury before;he was used to wooden floors and thin blankets.

The room was silent. Where were the sounds of the storm? The cadet listened carefully but, despite the thick duvet, he felt a knot tighten in his gut and a chill creep along his spine. Carefully, slowly… he peered out. The curtains were open. Hadnt he closed them? Suddenly the eyes of every doll in the room lit up.and turned to face him dead on.

He screamed. As every doll came to life in the darkness, their eyes alight with red or laser pink energy, legs and arms whirring with robotic precision, the cadet found himself surrounded by hundreds of tiny enemies all making their way towards him with a rapid and unstoppable gait both rigid yet compensating for obstacles like furniture. Wild, purple hair from each doll reached for him as if to embrace him in a deadly hug;to tie him up in lilac ropes and keep him always. They leapt, climbed and pulled themselves onto the bed where they engulfed him in hugs and words of affirmation.

"I love you."

"Dont worry , Im here now ."

"Y our friend forever."

"I want to play ."

The words, robotic and preprogrammed sounded menacing. The dolls kept coming, each crackled voice recording sounding like a caged animal clawing for release. He swung his arms wildly, diving under the sheets to escape and found himself pressed lower and lower with the sheer weight of the tiny monsters. There was a double clap and suddenly all was still above him. Tenuously he lifted his head to peek above the duvet. Piles of dolls fell to the floor silent and still as though switched off by some ethereal force. Lightning once more flashed across the large window alongside a crack of thunder. He froze in horror . She stood, silhouetted against the night sky. Behind her the spire crackled once more with a strange energy . Those accursed twintails twirled and danced like snakes, both

terrifying and mesmerising. The world seemed to stop in that instant causing him to freeze;eyes wide, mouth open.

"I heard you scream."

Her voice was high pitched, smile wide and her eyes sparkled with unbridled joy that somehow scared him more than the dolls ever had. He swallowed past a lump in his throat. His mouth felt so dry. He was in her bed! What would she do?

"These are my dolls," she said, a thousand hair strands placing them back into their original positions without her even looking. "They're programmed to comfort me if I have a nightmare although I don't really sleep here anymore, not after"…

The smile disappeared;the mask slammed down. Rising up, she crawled across the ceiling. She was right above him, hanging like a spider, a curtain of hair trapping him within a cocoon. She laughed, her head turning without her shoulders moving, until the blank metal stared at him, the red lenses penetrating his very soul. His eyes widened in horror. Her head was on backwards! Or was it a trick? Her body followed in a separate movement until it realigned. Looking down at him, she revealed her features.

"It's been so long since I had any visitors here." She arched her back and sighed, unwittingly pushing her chest towards him. "Feel free to stay as long as you want. You can use my room and…whatever else you need."

She winked, a coquettish eyebrow raised, and stared at him. He felt certain he was supposed to fill the awkward silence with something.

"Um…thanks," he ventured.

"Hmmm"… without warning she sprang to one side of the bed. Cross-legged she perched upon her hair, pulled out a datapad and became emersed in its pale blue glow. The cadet, startled from his

fear induced paralysis watched her features dance with joy at whatever she espied within the confines of the electronic gadget.

Feeling rather embarrassed he left the bed. It was chilly so he reached for his cape and swung it over his shoulders. Sliding the pin into position he felt the wool shield him from the cold. He slid his feet into his boots more out of habit than practicality. The knot in his stomach grew bigger, his throat dried up completely. Here he was, standing in front of the Princesses of Dryl without so much as a weapon. The Horde expected him to kill her or die in the attempt.

"Where did the storm go?" he asked, distracted. Her eyes shone as she looked up.

"Oh, it's not a real storm. It's localised. Wanna meet her?"

She didn't wait for an answer but bundled him up entirely in her hair which wound itself around his body like a constrictor. He squealed in fright as she ran to the window his body lifted high. He stared out into the darkness beyond, struggling against the tight trappings to no avail.

"Don't worry," she jumped onto the thin stone ledge outside the window, "it isn't far and it's so much fun!"

He screamed as she leapt and swung herself from ledge to ledge using her hair like hands. If she fell he would surely die but his cries only made her laugh louder and shriller until he couldn't hear himself anymore. She reached the edge of the castle and leapt to the outer wall;a direct route between her home and the spire itself. It was tall, very tall with a purple crystal at the top that glowed bright. As they approached the monument he realised the only way in was up. He closed his eyes as the princess hoisted them up the towering pole and through a window at the top.

Once inside, she dropped him unceremoniously on the floor. And then she was gone. Where? How? Staggering to his feet he saw it, the huge contraption. It spun and whirred in an erratic fashion. He

didn't know much about machinery but he'd learned to drive many vehicles. He walked around it, boots making clipped sounds against the cobbled floor. It was almost large enough to climb inside, for one person to steer perhaps. A shiver ran up his spine;something was amiss. He found himself looking at a bank of computer terminals. Shrouded in darkness, a figure sat upon a console in the centre, perfectly still, legs crossed, arms at either side, hands gripping the edge. Her face was in shadow, bent forwards so the mask with those horrifying red eyes bored into him from the top of her head. On either side those twin pillars cascaded around her shoulders, swirling at her feet whose purple boots ended two feet above the floor. He gasped as her head rose up, the smile bright but disarming, eyes glittering with far flung ideas and insightful knowledge and expertise.

"This is Illumina." She stroked the keyboard beside her and the console lit up with a faint lilac glow. "Isn't she beautiful?"

The cadet stood frozen to the spot. With her chest pushed forward, he felt his breath tighten, his heartrate increase. Was she a siren sent to lure him to his end? Did all Princesses possess the ability to coerce their prey to wanton acts before devouring them? Shadow Weaver's words of warning permeated his mind and an image of Rogelio, disappointed in him for giving in so easily, of Lonnie turning her back in disgust. No, he wouldn't be fooled by the spinster , he was not hers to own. The Princess lowered herself onto the console, highlighting her fabric covered breasts to him in the dim light. His eyes widened before he could blink them shut, he really didn't want to see that, fully clothed though she was. She lay across the console, head propped on one arm, hair fondling the keys and switches and then he realised. She wasn't flirting with him at all. It was Illumina she was interested in.

"Hello sweetheart. See, I told you I'd bring you someone juicy one day. We'll get this thing done, you'll see and then it'll be just us… forever."

She sat up once more, hair a tangled web of distressed keratin, greasy overalls now stuck to her small body as though she'd been

sweating. She looked at him as a predator would, her smile full of dark intent. He ran for the open window and jumped. Before he could grab the main trunk of the stone tower, tendrils and threads of hair reached him, grabbing every part they could encircle to tear him from his objective and pull him mercilessly back into the core of the crystal spire. She pulled him in close, their faces almost touching.

"Oh dont go yet," she said, teasingly, "I'm not done with my experiment."

"E.. experiment?" His mind flickered back to Shadow Weaver once more and suddenly the whole story came back to him in a horrifying flash of bone chilling reality.

"You..you're the Technological PPrincess! You dont have magic but you dont need it because"… her head tilted as his thoughts poured out unbidden, "Your parents died in a horrific explosion when you were a kid and..you want them back. That's why you dont sleep in your room because"…

The mask slammed down. She squeezed his bonds tight, "No! Dont talk about my parents! Ever!"

"The dolls were there to comfort you but after they died, they didnt work anymore."

"Stop!" the red eyes flashed and he found himself thrust inside the great machine.

"You tried to make a time machine to go back and save them. It cost you everything."

"No! I threw out the clocks and the mirrors. It's all going to be fine."

"But the machine broke. You're trapped inside a place where time is fractured. You dont age anymore. No-one here does!"

She strapped him in tight, sparks flying where the metal buckles connected with loose wires. "She needs a power source. I tried to fix her but we're all part of the same failed experiment. It has to be someone from outside the grid." The mask flew up again, her face once more filled with joy. "But now you're here, I can rewind time and go back to the day my parents died. I can stop it from happening!"

"But what about me?" he cried out in despair.

"You? Oh, you'll die, but my staff have already agreed that's ok. They wanna stop being trapped too. Sorry, it's four against one, five including Illumina, you lose."

The machine rumbled, glowing a bright amethyst. A tear fell. He would never again see his friends, never hear another of Shadow Weaver's terrifying tales, never eat another ration bar. He shut his eyes, preparing for the worst, when a cry of alarm reached him. The Princess had run to the computer, her frustrated fingers and hair typing rapidly into several keyboards at once. A small green head appeared, quickly undoing the straps and buckles.

"Hey, you're back!"

"Shh!" the last strap undone, she led him to an escape hatch. He swung down the thin rope, descending as fast as he dared, the goblin close behind. A scream of frustration revealed that the Princess had discovered her loss. At the bottom of the spire, a tiny door opened, leading once more to the courtyard of Crypto Castle.

"Why are you helping me? Aren't you part of the curse too?"

She led him towards the doorway, "When the first experiment failed, she tested the machine on me. It made me like this, but it's gonna kill you! You didn't ask for this, it's not fair."

He gasped. "Come with me. The Horde will look after you."

"I can't leave, none of us can! You have to go now, and don't come back!"

As lightning struck, silhouettes emerged; Bubblegirl, Baker and Soda Pop barred the way. Entrapta, boots thudding on the ground, cut off any chance of retreat. Baker braced herself as Wrong ran at her wasting no time. He pushed her to the ground, jumping over her to reach the wooden door. The exit was in his reach, his hand on the handle…

A coil of hair snaked around his waist and yanked him back. Soda Pop and Bubblegirl pulled at his arm, unwrapping each finger from the handle as yet more tendrils encroached. With a cry of attack he launched an elbow into Bubblegirl's eye, blinding her so that she ran off screaming. The purple darkness enveloped his thin body, the nightmarish Princess dragging him to his demise even as her cackle of triumph rose above the thunder. He drew closer and, as a last resort, grabbed as much hair from each pigtail as he could and pulled. Despite his lanky frame and weak arms his determination was fierce. She screamed, clawing at him but he pulled down, forcing her head forward, her hands to hold her head instead. The long tresses lay still, her distress rendering them immobile. Baker and Soda Pop advanced wielding a rolling pin and a broken bottle. Wrong swung with all his might, making the technological genius follow his lead until her feet left the ground with the centrifugal force. Her smaller body hit the servants hard enough to topple them. The goblin, ready with a rope, quickly tied up the servants and called out to him to leave.

Wrong hauled Entrapta to her feet and pulled her , backwards, towards the now open door. He didn't dare let go lest her hair regain its power. She resisted but, unable to turn, to fight him off, she couldn't break his grip. Terrified, shaking with adrenaline and fear he wondered at his own audacity as to drag a Princess screaming across her own territory.

"Let me go!" she pleaded as he tugged her ever onwards.

I'm not an experiment," he shouted back, "I'm worth something!"

"I know!" she cried out, looking at him upside down, "I calculated the odds. One life in exchange for many. If I hadn't brought you in, fed you, gave you a place to sleep, you'd be dead anyway. I saved your life so you could save all of them, my parents, the servants... and break the time loop!"

Thunder rattled across the empty sky as though Ilumina agreed.

"What if I do more research?" she pleaded, "Find a way to keep you alive?"

"And end up like her?" He pointed towards the tied-up servants but the goblin was gone.

"Who? Baker?"

"No, the green… The one you disfigured with your machine!"

"Wait, what... SANDRA? But... she's not disfigured. That little goblin! She's always interfering."

Ilumina, confused, said, "But she said you experimented on her."

"Ooh… that!" Entrapta clicked her fingers. Despite her awkward position she smiled wide, "Yeah, it didn't work. Actually she found and suggested you. Well, until I discovered you'd die in the process and she became... difficult. It's ok, free will is encouraged around here."

"What about my free will?"

She pressed a finger to her lips, "Hmmm, good point! I'll make a note of that." She pulled a recording device from a pocket and clicked a button, "Temporal Diaries Ethical Dilemma 110. Should free will of a subject due to die be a relevant parameter of experiment 13? Should subject's free-will be subservient to the greater good of saving

several thousand lives and the potential temporal dilation of the time bubble thereby saving the planet from total collapse"?

"What"?

"Oh, if Idont solve this thing fast the time bubble will collapse, taking the whole of reality with it! Etheria will be sucked into a void the size of a pinhead! Everything will be destroyed, isnt it faaascinating"?

The full reality of the situation hit him like a ton of bricks. His foot reached the threshold causing him to trip backwards beyond the boundary of the castle walls. Letting go of the Princess' hair he fell, alone, into the darkness of the night. Disorientated and afraid he ran, hellbent from the doomed domain, the sun now rising above the distant skyline. He didnt stop until he was far enough away to collapse onto the dirt track exhausted. What had she meant about the collapse of the time bubble? Had his leaving the fatal fortress sentenced the whole of Etheria to be crushed mercilessly into a void of darkness?

Two figures walked along the path. Relieved he waved them over and to his delight found Lonnie and Rogelio had come to find him. In excited tones he rapidly explained his infiltration of Crypto Castle and all his adventures within.

"Really Me"? Lonnie said with a sly smirk, "You expect us to believe you, of all people, went into Entrapta's castle, defeated her solo and lived to tell the tale"? Rogelio snorted in agreement, "And just what are you wearing"? The silk pyjamas shimmered beneath his cloak.

"Come on," she said, "let's get back to camp. Well tell them you hit your head or something."

He turned to leave with one last glance where the castle still stood, empty and derelict. He was sure he caught the sound of a cackle on the wind, just for a moment.

Chapter End Notes

Entrapta crawling across the ceiling is inspired by the film Trainspotting (1996).

Iaimed at a haunted house theme as Entraptas first episode System Failure also follows this formula and her castle is so interesting in itself. So many people describe Entrapta as the oldest princess but Im sure theres older ones and it just seemed a fun way to explore the mysteries of both her and the castle. A time loop just became a natural extension and a fun way to have people appear and disappear without warming or reason, adding to the horror.
At first this was going to be a nameless Horde Cadet but he just gives off vibes of Shaggy from Scooby Doo and he gets scared so easily it made more sense to have a familiar character in the role to bring the story to life. Naturally this led to using the kitchen staff and the goblin who helps Hordak.

Thanks to Xnakis for suggesting Imake the ending ambiguous rather than giving it a twist and to Tipsy for drawing an amazing picture which will be added as soon as its ready. Ilove it already.

## End Notes

I just want to thank everyone involved in this event for all your hard work and deliberation. These stories and art are a work of love and I (Breavedbuckle) appreciate you all standing by me to finish the project and give it your all to make it look this good. Thanks also to Xanakis and BrekoftheHorde for helping me set this up and keeping me right.

Thank you for making Shadow Weaver's dream of becoming a published author come true. She is very grateful and loves you all dearly.

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